Mishal Husain's *Broken Threads* begins with the actual frayed threads of a sari from her grandparents' wedding. A cousin uses its brocade border on a shawl, and gives it to Husain as a wedding present. Beyond this, though, the book contains surprisingly few object histories, for a family memoir in an age of Instagrammable nostalgia. It quickly becomes clear that Husain, a well-known BBC journalist, wasn't just looking for a place to inscribe her own memories. She had access to her grandparents' memories: "I had the books written by one grandparent (Shahid), an unpublished memoir left by another (Mumtaz), some audio tapes recording my grandmother Tahirah, and a 97-year-old sibling of Mary's to talk to," Husain says in an email interview. The book's structure stemmed from this: Chapters 1-4 are devoted, in succession, to her grandparents Mary, Mumtaz, Shahid and Tahirah.

THE POLITICAL DIVIDES OF THE 1930s AND '40s EMERGE MORE INTIMATELY HERE THAN IN MOST ACADEMIC HISTORIES

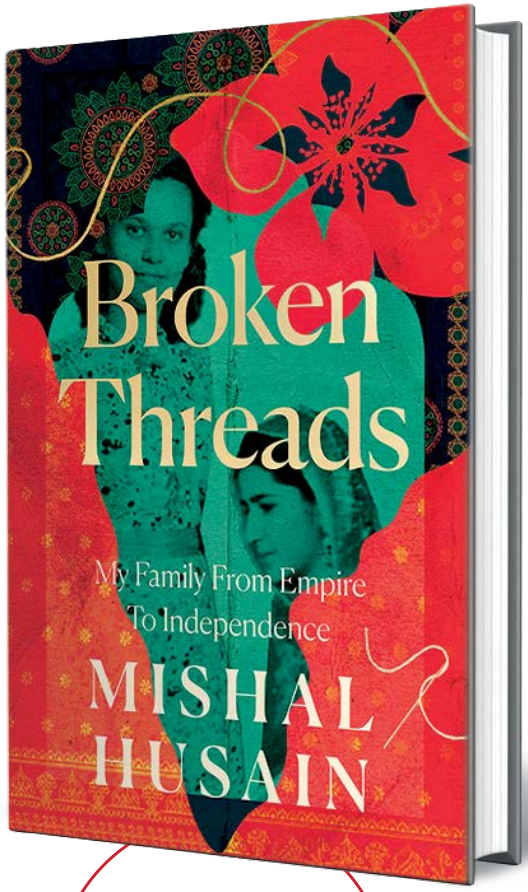
But the real achievement of *Broken Threads* lies in contextualising each grandparent's individual trajectory. "I realised early on that I needed to begin a few decades before, going back into the 19th century and the period before and after 1857," says Husain. "I turned it into history as well as memoir because I didn't feel I could understand these individuals without understanding their times."

We hear about Mary's childhood, for instance, only after Husain has described the arrival of Europeans in India. But instead of a generic history of the East India Company, Husain focuses on what is relevant to explain Mary Quinn, daughter of Mariamma and Francis Quinn: the relationships between Indian women and European men which led to the emergence of the Anglo-Indian community.

She does something similar with each grandparent, tapping into histories of communities, professions, ways of being. Writing about her grandfathers Mumtaz and Shahid enables her—and us—to dive into the modern South Asian histories of medicine and the army. As context for her grandmother Tahirah, who grew up in Aligarh, Husain provides a deft account of Syed Ahmad Khan and his awakening to the need for Western education for Muslims, who after 1857 had fallen into a state of nostalgia for the past and resistance to the future.

What brings all these threads together is the British colonial frame. As Husain puts it, she "felt the environment into which Shahid, Tahirah, Mumtaz and Mary were born, between 1911 and 1922, had been shaped by prior events and the entrenchment of British power". "They grew up seeing New Delhi being built as a grand capital...and I don't think they envisaged that era ending in their lifetimes," she tells INDIA TODAY. This may have been particularly true of Shahid, "who had a ringside seat to the circle of power in Delhi for the 18-month run-up to Independence and who wrote about that period, making clear his dim view of Lord Mountbatten." There is something deeply tragic about this portrait of her grandparents as part of a colonial elite in a united South Asia, who didn't feel at home anywhere after Independence and Partition.

Husain seems to share Shahid's sense of disappointment. "As a journalist working primarily on the UK," she says, writing *Broken Threads* made her return often to "a dispiriting reality: how did a nation with



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